

Call for Expressions of Interest

<i>Date of Issue:</i>	September 2026
<i>Expected Completion Date:</i>	May 2027
<i>Project Title:</i>	Advancing and enriching discovery and access: Interrogating archival catalogue data
<i>Company:</i>	Manuscripts and Special Collections, University of Nottingham

Contact Details

<i>Lead Contact:</i>	Laura Peaurt
<i>Lead E-mail:</i>	Laura.peaurt@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Charlotte May
<i>E-mail:</i>	Charlotte.may@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Kathryn Summerwill
<i>E-mail:</i>	Kathryn.summerwill@nottingham.ac.uk
<i>Additional Contact:</i>	Additional contact name
<i>E-mail:</i>	Additional contact e-mail

Additional Info

<i>Students must sign NDA:</i>	☒
<i>Project uses personal data:</i>	☒
<i>Custom hardware required:</i>	☐ If Applicable: Please provide details
<i>Relevant research areas (if applicable)¹:</i>	Digital humanities, natural language processing, metadata analysis [decolonisation?] [hidden histories?]

Project Background Information

Manuscripts and Special Collections (MSC), the archive at the University of Nottingham, uses collections management software to catalogue their collections of archive material and rare printed books.

Archives are catalogued in a system called Calm, by Axiell. Users can browse the Calm catalogue records using the frontend CalmView ([Manuscripts Online Catalogue](#)). More limited versions of Calm records are also available in NUsearch.

Rich descriptive metadata held in Calm is used as the basis for all other forms of enquiry, discovery, research and analysis of our collections. This takes the form of extensive structured xml metadata

Metadata has been created and added to by staff in the archive since (at least?) the 1950s. This has meant:

- Changes in descriptive practice over time has left legacy data with inconsistent terminology for places, people and other keywords

¹ An overview of different research areas in the school of computer science can be found [here](#).

○ Key information such as restrictions on access may not be consistently applied across the catalogue • Presence of outdated, historically inaccurate, Eurocentric, biased or offensive language • Mix of controlled entry fields and fields with extensive unstructured textual descriptions. We are able to search across the catalogue in an advanced way. However it is not possible to easily analyse and identify either connections between the data, similar content or easily draw together all the possible ways an entity (such as a place or person) may have been entered into the catalogue to assist with addressing problematic entries and supporting standardisation work.	
Requirements	
MSC would like to be able to use a wider range of tools and methods to interrogate the catalogue to enable: • Extraction of named entities from unstructured text fields to support ○ Identification of research strengths, unknown connections in collection data ○ Flagging issues of linguistic bias, harmful text and outdated spellings and support integration of inclusive terminologies ○ Identify synonyms and contextually similar entities and terms (e.g. searching for 'environment' might also pull back related terms such as 'sustainability', 'climate change' etc etc) • Support standardisation of key information fields such as rights and restrictions data • Provide a basis for future work to support identification of under indexing of local creators and terminologies (e.g., readdress historical Eurocentric approaches to cataloguing work) Ideally these enhanced methods of searching would be available for staff to interpret the data and plan future work. This work could lead to future projects to identify methods of adding this additional information back into catalogue for discovery and access whilst retaining the provenance and history of different cataloguing practices over time.	
Skills	
<i>Highly desirable:</i> <i>Experience in or interest in using machine learning in interpreting printed materials</i>	<i>Desirable:</i> <i>Interest in archives</i> <i>Interest in digital humanities</i> <i>Interest in ethics of digital representation of marginalised communities.</i>
Submission / Award information	
<i>Date of Submission:</i>	September 2026
<i>Date of Pitch:</i>	October 2026
<i>Notification of award:</i>	October 2026

For further information on this proposal, the team representative should in the first instance e-mail the lead contact stated above at the e-mail address provided.